SUMMARY

I analyzed HR records from 1,470 employees to understand what drives people to leave, and built a system that can flag at-risk employees before they resign. After comparing three different approaches, our best model correctly identified around 8 out of 10 employees who were genuinely likely to leave.

The data pointed to three factors that matter most. First, overtime is the strongest warning sign — employees working beyond standard hours consistently showed the highest exit rates, suggesting that overwork culture is quietly pushing people out. Second, salary plays a role, but mainly at the lower end — junior employees who feel financially undervalued start looking elsewhere early. Third, and perhaps most actionable, roughly one-third of all departures happen within the first year. This is not really about money — it is about onboarding, unmet expectations, and whether new hires feel set up to succeed.

When it comes to which teams need attention most urgently, Sales stands out clearly. Sales Representatives leave at a rate close to 40%, nearly double that of any other role in the company. If HR has limited bandwidth for retention efforts, this is where to start.

On the question of whether salary alone explains attrition — the answer is no. Employees doing heavy overtime leave even when reasonably paid. Work-life balance and early career experience matter just as much as the paycheck, which means raising salaries without fixing working conditions will only slow departures, not stop them.

Two practical steps HR could take immediately are: having direct conversations with Sales Representatives about workload and career path, and introducing a structured 90-day check-in for all new hires to catch dissatisfaction before someone has already decided to leave. The model is a starting point, not a verdict — but used thoughtfully, it tells HR exactly where to focus their energy.